EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

A Reason for Every Misvah?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 3:2

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 3, Chapter 2 (second half: reasons for the revealed mitzvot), with the opening question of Chapter 3
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 16 September 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

Essay 1 was about creation, Essay 2 about the unity of God, and Essay 3 is about **mitzvot and revelation**.

- **The Introduction:** HaKadosh Baruch Hu created the world to **bestow goodness**, "a theme which the Ramchal will develop some 700 years later." He gave us mitzvot and aveirot so that we would work for that good, because "when you work for something in life, you benefit more and you enjoy it more."
- **Chapter 1:** two categories of mitzvot. The **rational** mitzvot fall into three groups: serving and thanking Hashem (tefillah, the Temple service), reverence for Hashem (not cursing, not taking His name in vain), and social conduct. The second category is mitzvot logic does not dictate, given, in Rav Saadia's words from Yeshayahu, so that Hashem might **"make the Torah great and glorious"** and increase our reward. Like the Midrash: does HaKadosh Baruch Hu care whether you slaughter through half or most of the signs? He gave them to give us more opportunities to serve Him, like a worker paid for work whose purpose he may not understand. And the rational mitzvot are **implanted within us**: morality is objective.
- **Chapter 2, part 1:** the reasons for four rational mitzvot. **Murder** defeats Hashem's will to bestow good. **Adultery** means not knowing who your father is, so you cannot show gratitude, and inheritance breaks down. **Theft** discourages cultivating your talents and the world. **Dishonesty** contradicts our senses and causes cognitive dissonance. And "good" cannot mean "good for me," since the same act would be good for me and bad for you, like honey laced with poison. "Pleasure is not the sole criterion of what is good."

Tonight: the second half of Chapter 2, the **revealed** mitzvot.

Chapter 2, Part 2: Five Categories of Revealed Mitzvot

Rav Saadia turns to mitzvot that are not immediately logical, "perhaps neutral from the perspective of reason," where Hashem chose to make some things sacred, some forbidden, some permitted and the rest neutral. He discusses five:

#	Category	What is distinguished
1	**Sacred days**	Shabbat and festivals, set apart from ordinary days
2	**Sacred people**	Kohanim and prophets, set apart from everyone else
3	**Food**	Some foods forbidden, some permitted
4	**Forbidden relations**	Some people forbidden, some permitted, some obligatory
5	**Times of separation**	Times when relations with one's wife are forbidden

Although the main purpose, as Chapter 1 explained, is to increase our service of Hashem and our reward, "I still find some partial rationale for them." And yet **the wisdom of God is above us**.

Ta'am: a taste

The Rabbi noted that the **Sefer HaChinuch** says exactly the same in its introduction: I will give you reasons for all the mitzvot, but never forget that Hashem's wisdom is above all of this. "It's a beautiful idea. A taste in Hebrew is **ta'am**, and a reason is also **ta'am**." Even when you think you understand a mitzvah, you only have a taste of it, never the whole picture.

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1. Shabbat and the Festivals

Rav Saadia gives several reasons:

- **Rest.** Simply, humans need rest.
- **Developing the intellect.** Free from work, there is time to study.
- **Spiritual growth.** We pray more on Shabbat.
- **Social value.** People meet one another and talk, and it is a time for public announcements.

"Saadia is seeing spiritual, moral and social value in Shabbat and the festivals."

What about the Torah's reasons?

The Rabbi pointed out that the Torah itself does give rest as a reason: **למען ינוח עבדך ואמתך כמוך**, "so that your servant and your maidservant may rest like you" (Devarim 5:14). "People forget. The Torah does say, black and white, *lema'an yanuach*." And that is Rav Saadia's first reason.

He repeated an idea he has taught before:

"We are human beings, not human doings. During the six days we are human doings. Shabbat allows us to be human beings." That is why on Shabbat you are not meant to prepare for the future or work on your goals and aspirations. "It's about being in the present."

The Torah also gives creation in six days and the memory of Egypt as reasons, and it is interesting that Rav Saadia does not mention them. Perhaps he includes them in "developing the intellect": studying the creation of the world, that there is a God, the Exodus.

Chaim was struck by the social reason: in an agricultural society, every farmer was alone in his own field and rarely met the others. Shabbat brought the community together. "Exactly. It's so important," said the Rabbi. "Very pragmatic."

Torah or rest?

The Rabbi brought the **Yerushalmi**, cited in the halachah by the **Rema** (Orach Chaim 290). Two Amoraim disagree: one says Shabbat was given for **Torah study**, the other for **rest**. The Gemara reconciles them: for working people, who do not study during the week, Shabbat is for Torah. For the scholars who labour in Torah all week, Shabbat is for rest. He recalled a gloss there, he thought by **Rav Yaakov Emden**, saying that on Shabbat one should not study in great depth but revise, read Navi and Chumash. So Shabbat is a combination of a bit of Torah and a bit of rest, and that is where Rav Saadia gets his two ideas of developing wisdom and resting.

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2. Kohanim and Prophets

Why are certain people singled out for reverence? So that we can **learn from them**. Rav Saadia is drawing directly on Malachi:

> For the lips of the Kohen guard knowledge, and they seek **כי שפתי כהן ישמרו דעת ותורה יבקשו מפיהו** Torah from his mouth. (Malachi 2:7)

"People forget this. People think the Kohen was serving the whole time in the Beit HaMikdash. It's absolutely wrong." Each Kohen served only about **two weeks a year** in the rotation, and not full-time even then. The rest of the time his role was **to learn and teach Torah**. If everyone has to work, nobody is free to teach, so you must designate people. Rav Saadia lists their roles: to teach, to pray on the people's behalf, to inspire them to a pious path and develop their character, and to set people back on the right path. "Both spiritual aspects and social aspects. He's your teacher, he's your guide, he's your mentor."

A participant added that kohanim and prophets are **representatives** of Hashem, like a king's councillors whom one respects. **Mark** suggested it teaches the importance of **delegation**: the Kohen is, as it were, Hashem's manifestation in this world, which is why the firstborn, which belongs to Hashem, is given to the Kohen. "Interesting," said the Rabbi.

Another participant said the Kohen **intercedes** for the people. The Rabbi brought the **Maharal**: the word **כהן** has the numerical value **75**. Seven represents the natural world; eight represents what is above it. The Kohen, at 75, stands between the people, the "seventy", and Hashem, the "eighty". He added that the **Kuzari** sees the Kohen as a distinct level within Israel. Nowadays, he noted, the Kohen does not have that role, and the closest equivalent is the Chachamim.

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3. Kashrut

"You've got many different reasons given in the Rishonim. This reason you've probably never heard before. The most original reason I've ever seen."

Why may we eat some animals and not others? So that people never make the mistake, as happened in pagan times, of **associating animals with gods**.

If some animals are permitted and others impure, then no animal can be an object of worship. How can you worship something you are allowed to eat? That was the whole point in Egypt: if the lamb is a deity, how could you slaughter it? And the forbidden animals are not forbidden because they are holy. The Torah calls them **tamei**, impure. So both sides of the law strip animals of any divine status.

A participant who has been vegetarian most of her life did not follow. Another asked whether the permitted animals might still be taken for gods, or the forbidden ones considered holy, like a "lion king". The Rabbi

explained: "If you can eat it, it can hardly be something you can worship. And if you can't eat it, it's not because it's holy. It's because it's *tamei*." So the laws of kashrut are about keeping us away from **avodah zarah**.

Other Rishonim give other reasons: the **Rambam** in the Moreh Nevuchim writes, in a famous and difficult passage, that some of the laws are for **health**. Elsewhere it is explained that predatory animals would instil their **character** in the one who eats them.

The first to give reasons for mitzvot

The Rabbi stressed what a landmark this is:

"Saadia Gaon is the very first person to give reasons for mitzvot. This in itself is huge. We're seeing the most original reasons."

Later came the Rambam, the Sefer HaChinuch, the Ramban, the Abarbanel and many commentators. But you never find the Gemara or the Geonim doing anything like this. He is the first, right at the end of the Gaonic period. A participant suggested people surely discussed reasons before, perhaps without daring to write them down. "The first one to document it, the first which we have," the Rabbi agreed.

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4. Forbidden Relations: Incest

Adultery was already explained among the rational mitzvot. But why are a man and his sister, or a father and his daughter, forbidden? Rav Saadia gives two reasons:

1. **Constant proximity.** You spend so much time with your siblings and parents that, if they were permitted, there would be relations all the time, an increase in promiscuity, "and too much isn't good."
2. **Marriageability.** If relatives could marry, some people would never be sought by anyone outside. Others would reason: this girl's own brother passes her over for her sister, so neither will I. People would pursue only physical beauty, "and relationships are much more than external, hedonistic pleasure and physical beauty."

The Rabbi admitted a difficulty with the first reason: your wife is also available to you all the time, so what is the difference? And the laws of *niddah* would apply to a sister as well. "So I don't fully understand this reason."

Other reasons

- The **Rambam** develops the first reason too: the Torah repeats the many forms of forbidden relations so that we keep away from constant intimacy. He adds that it is unfitting to have relations with someone you must **honour and revere**. How can you honour your mother, or a daughter respect her father, after such intimacy? **Marie** had made exactly this point: it would ruin the relationship. "Very good. That's exactly what the Rambam says."
- Another reason given: marrying out brings in wealth and connections, rather than trapping them within the family.
- A participant noted that **Freud** also discussed the incest taboo, and another recalled the **Roman emperors** who married their sisters, whose children then had higher status and caused rivalry with half-siblings.

"Too much kindness"

The Rabbi has said before that the Torah calls one of these relations **חסד הוא** (Vayikra 20:17). Onkelos translates it as disgrace, but the simple meaning is "overflowing kindness." Love between brother and sister, father and daughter, is a great love, "but even love has to have a boundary." There is *chesed* that is bad: constantly helping someone without giving him independence. A participant added that even between husband and wife the period of separation guards against familiarity breeding contempt.

"Abomination"

Doron asked: the Torah calls these relations **תועבות**, abominations, which the Canaanites did and for which the land became defiled. The Rambam's reasons explain why they would be abominable. Rav Saadia's pragmatic reasons do not. The Rabbi agreed that Rav Saadia's reasons are pragmatic, and suggested that perhaps he reads "abomination" as going on the last items in the list.

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5. Times of Separation

Why may a man not be with his wife at certain times?

1. **Humility and restraint.** The Rabbi understood it as recognising the limits of one's flesh: you cannot indulge it all the time.
2. **Appreciation of the spiritual.** Rav Saadia seems to hold that after relations a person was impure and could not enter the Temple, or, in his view, pray, until purified. The period of separation therefore gives time to focus on these things and appreciate them, and instils fear of heaven. (Nowadays, the Rabbi noted, one may pray.)

Other Rishonim give other reasons. The **Sefer HaChinuch** and others relate it to the Torah's term **דוה**, as if it were a kind of illness that could be caught, "which scientifically is not correct nowadays." Another reason given: the purpose of relations is ultimately **procreation**, which is not possible at that time.

Rav Saadia mentions that he will discuss other mitzvot later, such as the **red heifer**, the **korbanot**, the **eglah arufah** and **brit milah**. Here he only wants to give a taste. He concludes that in all the revealed mitzvot you will find branches of reason, many reasons. But ultimately Hashem's wisdom is higher than anything humans can attain:

> As the heavens are higher than the earth, so are My ways **כי גבהו שמים מארץ כן גבהו דרכי מדרכיכם** higher than your ways. (Yeshayahu 55:9)

Sichliyot and Shim'iyot; Mishpatim and Chukim

At the opening of Chapter 3, Rav Saadia names the categories for the first time:

Rav Saadia	Meaning	The Rambam's terms
(*sichliyot*) **שכליות**	Mitzvot that **reason** can dictate	**Mishpatim**
(*shim'iyot*) **שמעיות**	Mitzvot we know because we **heard** them, by revelation	**Chukim**

There is no mitzvah without a reason

The Rabbi called this crucial. Ask most people, even children, what a *chok* is, and they will say: a mitzvah with no reason, and the classic example is the **parah adumah**. "No. The Rambam rejects that," and he argues strongly with the Ramban about it.

For the Rambam, a *mishpat* is a mitzvah whose reason is immediately apparent. A *chok* is one **whose reason takes longer to understand**. There is no such thing as a mitzvah with no reason. People who say God gives mitzvot without reasons are embarrassing HaKadosh Baruch Hu. "You don't know the reason for it. That doesn't mean it's got no reason."

A participant asked about **Shlomo HaMelech**, who said of the red heifer, **אמרתי אחכמה והיא רחוקה ממני**, "I said I would become wise, but it was far from me." Every year we read the reasons and still do not understand. The Rabbi answered that Shlomo said *he* did not grasp it fully, not that it had no reason. "If he didn't think you need to understand it, he wouldn't have said it." It shows that you **must try** to understand the mitzvot, even if you do not always succeed.

Another participant noted that for Rav Saadia, the main point of the revealed mitzvot is still obedience and service, and their partial benefits are secondary. "Correct. Good point."

Which category is higher?

Rav Saadia does not say which category is more important. Is a rational mitzvah higher, because it is basic morality? Or a revealed one, because Hashem had to reveal it? The Rabbi noted that we are told not to weigh up the positive mitzvot against each other, as the Rambam taught, whereas the negative ones can be weighed by their punishments. On this question there is a dispute, and he asked the class to guess who says what:

	View
The Kuzari	The **revealed** mitzvot are higher. **החקים השכליים הם הקדמות והצעות לתורה האלהית**: the rational laws are only a preface and introduction to the divine Torah, like *derech eretz kadmah laTorah*
Rabbeinu Bachya	The **rational** mitzvot are more important, precisely because they are rational

Is there an accepted reason?

A participant asked which reason is the accepted one today. "Now we appreciate what the Shulchan Aruch did," the Rabbi said. With halachah there were the Rambam, the Rosh and many others reaching different conclusions, so the Shulchan Aruch gave a ruling. In practice there is a *psak*. With understanding and reasons there is none. "It's your decision, what makes the most sense to you. You can have your own reason." The *ta'amim* are only as far as the human mind can recognise.

The participant felt some things, like the incest taboo, are simply embedded in the human mind. The Rabbi suggested Rav Saadia would say there were times when people did these things, and that the **Bible's influence** over thousands of years may have made them repugnant to us. Another participant pointed out that the **Code of Hammurabi**, older than the Torah, already forbids it. "True," said the Rabbi, though if Hammurabi had to legislate against it, perhaps people were doing it.

Chapter 3: Why Do We Need Revelation for What Reason Can Tell Us?

Chapter 3 asks: if the rational mitzvot can be worked out by reason, why do we need **prophets and revelation** for them? Rav Saadia has in mind the **Brahmins**, a Hindu sect who held a kind of **natural religion**, like modern **deism**: you believe in God, but you know what is good and bad by yourself. "I don't need someone to tell me. Just do what your heart feels is right." He accepts that we need revelation for the *shim'iyot*. The question is about the *sichliyot*.

The Rabbi noted that Rav Saadia already gave one answer in the Introduction to the book: people could work these things out themselves, but **it would take time**, and in the meantime they would stumble. Revelation gave us an immediate "yes" and "no."

At this point the Zoom connection froze repeatedly, and the shiur ended there.

Summary

1. **The revealed mitzvot** have a partial rationale, but Hashem's wisdom is above us. A *ta'am* is only a taste.
2. **Shabbat and festivals:** rest, study, prayer and community. "Human beings, not human doings." For the worker, Torah; for the scholar, rest.
3. **Kohanim and prophets:** set apart to **teach**, pray, guide and inspire. The Kohen served only about two weeks a year.
4. **Kashrut:** so that no animal can be taken for a god, the most original reason the Rabbi had seen. Rav Saadia is **the first to give reasons for mitzvot**.
5. **Incest:** to prevent constant promiscuity, and so that everyone is marriageable. The Rambam adds the honour owed to parents. Even *chesed* needs boundaries.
6. **Niddah:** humility, and time to appreciate the spiritual.
7. **Sichliyot and shim'iyot**, the Rambam's mishpatim and chukim. For the Rambam, no mitzvah lacks a reason; a *chok* is one whose reason is harder to grasp.
8. **Which is higher?** The Kuzari favours the revealed, Rabbeinu Bachya the rational.
9. **Chapter 3:** why reveal what reason can find? Partly because reason takes time, and revelation spares us stumbling on the way.

Coming Up

The rest of **Chapter 3**: Rav Saadia's full answer to why revelation is needed even for the rational mitzvot.

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